



TEHRAN IRAN

Persian Polo in Tehran

Tehran is an almost frenetically busy city, with broad streets, roaring traffic, and a great, seething bazaar – not to mention some of the country's best restaurants – all lying in the shadow of the mighty, snow-capped Alborz Mountains. It's just the place to hunt down one of the many variations of *polo*, the most exquisite of Persian rice dishes.



The Iranian capital cannot really be called a beautiful city. A sprawling, exhaust-filled metropolis with some eight million inhabitants, it is a place more usually associated with concrete blocks and seemingly endless streams of traffic. But look a little beyond this and you will find green parks, opulent palaces, and some of the country's finest museums. To visit Iran without spending any time here is to miss something of what makes the country tick.

Though the history of Tehran stretches back several thousand years, it was not until the end of the 18th century that it became the Iranian capital under the Qajar dynasty. And if the modern city cannot itself be called beautiful, some of its surroundings certainly can. Tehran sits on a plain at the foot of the enormous Alborz Mountains. One of these, the volcanic Mount Damavend, is the highest mountain in Iran – an enormous, snow-streaked cone, almost perfectly symmetrical, that still belches sulfur from its summit. Rich in associations with Persian folklore, the Alborz are now best known for their ski slopes and resorts, in particular Dizin and Tochal, accessible by a cable-car route that stretches from the more affluent northern suburbs of Tehran.

Tehran also has some excellent restaurants, from simple kebab shops to traditional places serving luxuriant rice dishes, such as *polo*. The rice in *polo* dishes is prepared using an elaborate cooking method known as *chelo*, during which the rice is washed, soaked, boiled until almost cooked, spread on the bottom of a heavy-bottomed pan (already coated with butter or oil), and finally steamed, very slowly, with a cloth under the lid to absorb any drips. When cooked properly, a thick golden crust, called *tah-dig*, forms on the bottom of the pan; it is served separately and is always a much-sought-after item at the Persian table. *Chelo* rice is heaped high on plates and served in generous portions to accompany kebabs, *khoresh* (stews), and other dishes.

In *polo* recipes, half the cooked rice is added to the buttered pan, and then cooked chicken, meat, or other ingredients are added. A second layer of rice is spread on top, and finally the whole dish is steamed. There are numerous well-known *polo* recipes, from *zereshk polo-e morgh* (with saffron, chicken, and barberries) and *shirin polo* (with orange peel, saffron, almonds, and pistachios), to its most elaborate and decadent form, *tachin*. There's even a fresh herby version that is the perfect accompaniment to fish – *sabzi polo*.

A Day in Tehran

The majority of Tehran's sites are concentrated close to downtown, but a few – such as the Azadi Tower – are farther out; they can easily be reached by bus, metro, or taxi. The vast (and incomplete) Imam Khomeini Shrine is on the road to Ghom.

MORNING Start from Imam Khomeini metro station, and walk south to visit the 16th-century **Golestan Palace**, site of the Qajar court in the 18th century.

AFTERNOON Return to Imam Khomeini metro station, taking a slight detour to walk through part of Tehran's enormous **bazaar**, and stop at the **Khayyam Traditional Restaurant** for lunch. Visit the **National Museum**, which has a fascinating archaeological collection showcasing the country's long history, and the small **Ceramics and Glass Museum**, which has excellent modern displays.

EVENING Walk northwest, crossing the busy Enqelab Avenue to reach the **Carpet Museum**, the **Museum of Contemporary Art**, and **Park Laleh**, one of the most pleasant green spaces in the city.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Imam Khomeini International Airport lies 22 miles (35 km) from Tehran; there are shared or private **taxis** into town. **Buses** and **trains** connect Tehran with most places in Iran.

WHERE TO STAY

Mashhad Hostel (inexpensive) is a hostel with rooms and dorms. www.mashhadhostel.com
Atlas (moderate) is a good mid-range hotel with a small garden. www.atlas-hotel.com
Ferdowsi Grand Hotel (expensive) is central and comfortable. www.ferdowsihotel.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.itto.org

